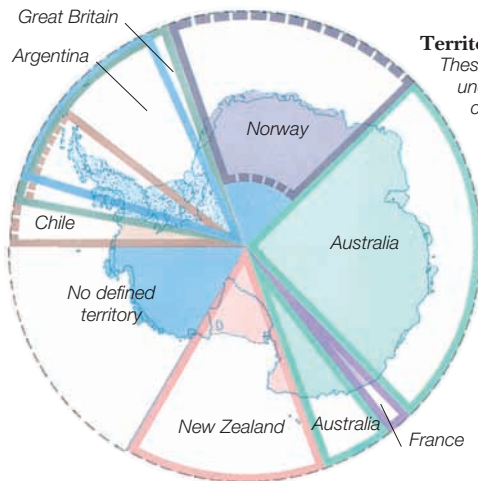


# THE ANTARCTIC

UNLIKE THE ARCTIC, which is an ocean surrounded by continents, the Antarctic is a continent surrounded by oceans. Antarctica is the most remote, inhospitable place on Earth and consists of a large land mass and numerous offshore islands. Most of the mainland is covered by a vast ice cap, which breaks up at the coastline, forming huge icebergs up to 125 miles (200 km) long. Antarctica is the only continent that has no permanent human population – the only inhabitants are visiting scientists studying the local environment. It is also unique in being governed by an international treaty that forbids countries from owning or exploiting the land.



**Territorial claims in the Antarctic**  
These claims have been suspended under the Antarctic Treaty. Stations can be set up for research, but military activities are forbidden.

By taking samples of ice from deep inside the ice cap, scientists are able to study changes in the climate.



**STUDYING ANTARCTICA**  
Scientists from all over the world come to Antarctica to study its unique climate, weather, geology, and wildlife. The age-old rocks tell them much about the development of the Earth, while analysis of the many meteorites that hit the ice cap provides valuable information about the Universe.

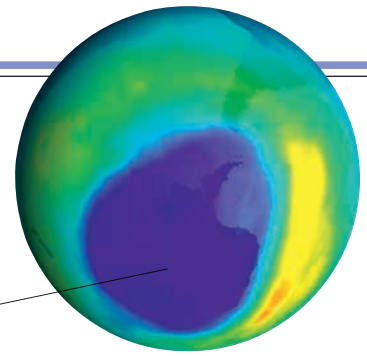
## THE ANTARCTIC TREATY

In the first half of the 20th century, many countries claimed territory in Antarctica. In order to prevent future conflict, 12 countries signed the Antarctic Treaty in 1959, which suspended all national claims to the land. The treaty designated Antarctica as “a continent for science,” and stated that it should be used for peaceful purposes only. Today, 45 countries have signed the treaty, which is one of the most successful examples of international cooperation.

Captain Roald Amundsen taking sights at the South Pole in 1911.

## ANTARCTIC EXPLORATION

It wasn't until 1820 that the shores of Antarctica were first sighted. From the 1840s onward, explorers began to map the continent, but the South Pole remained unknown. In the summer of 1911–12, two expeditions – one from Norway led by Roald Amundsen, the other from Britain led by Robert Scott – set out to reach the Pole. Amundsen arrived on December 14, followed by Scott a month later.



The hole in the ozone layer above Antarctica is the largest ever observed by scientists.

## CLIMATE

The ozone layer is between 9–19 miles (15–30 km) up in the stratosphere. It protects the Earth from the sun's harmful rays by absorbing ultraviolet radiation. In recent years, scientists have observed a hole in the ozone layer above Antarctica. The hole is three times larger than the U.S. and has caused huge concern about the production of ozone-destroying gases. This finding suggests Antarctica is much more fragile than was previously thought.



The American-owned Amundsen-Scott base is situated at the South Pole.

## RESEARCH STATIONS

Barely 1,000 people live in Antarctica in the winter, with another 3,000 joining them during the summer months. All are involved in scientific research and live on one of the 46 or so bases dotted around the continent. Each base is specially insulated against the intense cold and some have been constructed below the surface in order to conserve heat. Diesel fuel is used for heating and generating electricity, and enough fuel, food, and other supplies are kept to last 12 months, in case weather prevents new supplies from being brought in.

## TOURISM

Each year, a few intrepid tourists visit Antarctica, exploring the dramatic coastline in cruise ships or flying inland over the ice to land at the South Pole. So far, the small number of tourists has had little effect on the environment. However, the environment is threatened by the garbage slowly accumulating around the older scientific bases.

Cruise liners have been bringing tourists to Antarctica since the 1950s, and now bring about 10,000 people each year.

